
MONDAY
May 4, 2026
LIVE
BREAKING
NEWS
THE ATTENTION ECONOMY: IS VIRAL A REAL CAREER?
10:20 AM
24 NEWS
1% OF CREATORS MAKE 99% OF THE MONEY. WE'RE MOVING AWAY FROM MAKING THINGS AND TOWARD MAKING NOISE. IS THIS SUSTAINABLE OR A PYRAMID SCHEME?

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#1

THE CONTEXT

5 W'S

24 NEWS

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BY: ADARSHA

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The Context (5 W’s)

WHO: Affects over 430 million creators globally, with a sharp divide between the 1% elite and 99% hobbyists.

WHAT: The "Attention Economy" is a market where human focus is the primary commodity, often valued over physical production. A market where human focus is the primary commodity. In an "information-rich" world, wealth of information creates a scarcity of attention.

WHERE: While global in reach, North America dominates with a $50.9 billion market share in 2024. Dominates social platforms like Instagram (57% brand preference) and TikTok (52%), where commerce and content have collapsed into a single moment.

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WHEN: Shifted from a 2010s "hobbyist" era to a 2026 structural reset where production is commoditized by AI and revenue is driven by conversion, not just reach.We are currently in a 2026 Structural Reset; influencer marketing has matured from an "experiment" into a $34.1 billion core business pillar.

WHY: Driven by the decline of traditional TV (56% of Gen Z prefer creator content) and the rise of platform-native commerce like TikTok Shop. Traditional advertising is losing trust. 69% of consumers now trust influencer recommendations over brand-led ads.

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The Context (5 W's)

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#2

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

CORE CONCEPTS, TAKEAWAY, AND DATA

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> **TRADE-** Creators trade money for attention (sponsorships, advertisements and commercials). The attention economy connects to trades by turning human focus into a scarce, marketable commodity that drives investment, asset prices, and career choices. It is traded for profit by digital platforms and advertisers, the attention becomes the currency and platforms like Facebook, Youtube, Instagram and Tiktok act as brokers.

> **AUTOMATION-** "Algorithms". The attention economy and automation are deeply intertwined, with AI and machine learning acting as the engine that powers both the capture of human focus and the automation of digital tasks. Automation connects to economy because it controls the content people see online. Platforms like Youtube and Tiktok use algorithms to increase engagement and it makes content easier to go viral.

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ECONOMIC ANALYSIS- CORE CONCEPT

9:25 AM

HOW IT CONNECTS TO TRADE, AUTOMATION, INEQUALITY AND INFLATION

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> INEQUALITY- "Not everybody has the same or equal chance to go viral or earn money". The attention economy connects to inequality by treating human focus as finite and marketable commodity. Algorithms are designed to maximize engagement and prioritize high-performing content leading to a "rich-get-richer" scenario where popular creators gain more attention while small creators are left unnoticed.

> INFLATION- "Cost of Living vs. Unstable Influencer Income". It connects directly to inflation because it treats human focus as a finite resource causing the cost of that attention to increase and driving consumer spending through viral content. Going viral is recognized as a real career but volatile with the influencer market expanding into $34 billion industry by 2026.

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ECONOMIC ANALYSIS- CORE CONCEPT

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HOW IT CONNECTS TO TRADE, AUTOMATION, INEQUALITY AND INFLATION

BY: JOSH

TAKEAWAY 1: Attention Is the New Currency

Platforms don't sell content. They sell YOUR attention to advertisers. Creators are workers; platforms are owners.

SCARCITY

Attention is finite. We have only 24 hours in a day. Platforms compete to capture as much of it as possible.

LABOR THEORY

Creators produce value (content) but platforms capture the surplus value through ad revenue splits and control.

MARKET POWER

A few platforms (YouTube, TikTok, Meta) control distribution. This oligopoly lets them set terms that favor themselves.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR THE TEST: THE ATTENTION ECONOMY IS A REAL MARKET WITH REAL ECONOMIC STRUCTURES — SCARCITY, LABOR EXPLOITATION, AND CONCENTRATED MARKET POWER. "GOING VIRAL" DOESN'T GUARANTEE WEALTH BECAUSE THE SYSTEM IS DESIGNED TO BENEFIT PLATFORMS AND TOP CREATORS, NOT THE AVERAGE USER.

THE TAKEAWAY- BIG IDEA

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WHAT EVERYBODY NEEDS TO KNOW

BY: ADARSHA

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TAKEAWAY 2: Viral Is a Lottery, Not a Career Plan

96% of creators earn under $100K. The "viral career" is statistically a lottery — a few winners, millions of losers.

THE LOTTERY MATH

50%+

earn under **$15,000/year** — below minimum wage for full-time work

4%

earn six figures — the "visible" winners everyone sees

THE TAKEAWAY:

- GOING VIRAL IS CONSIDERED AND RECOGNIZED AS A REAL CAREER BUT IT IS ALSO UNSTABLE AND CONTROLLED BY ALGORITHMS SO NOT EVERYONE HAS THE SAME CHANCE OF GOING VIRAL AND EARNING MONEY THROUGH IT. THE ATTENTION ECONOMY TURNS POPULARITY/ATTENTION INTO INCOME OR REAL MONEY THROUGH ADVERTISEMENTS AND SPONSORSHIPS, BUT IT IS NOT RELIABLE LONG-TERM BECAUSE IT DEPENDS HEAVILY ON AUTOMATED ALGORITHMS WHICH CAN QUICKLY CHANGE AND AFFECT A CREATOR'S INCOME.

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THE TAKEAWAY- BIG IDEA

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WHAT EVERYBODY NEEDS TO KNOW

BY: JOSH

Nano Influencers (1k-10k Followers)- $10-$100 per post
Micro Influencers (10k-50k Followers)- $200-$1000
Mid Tier Influencers (50k-500k Followers)- $1000-$10000 per post (often full-time creators)
Macro/Mega Influencers (500k-1m+ Followers)- $10000-$100000+ per campaign

Youtube Ad Revenue generally ranges from $0.001 to $0.03 per view ($1 to $30 per 1000 views)

MORE DATA!

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HOW INFLUENCERS EARN MONEY

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THANK YOU!

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